

Core Mechanics: The Paranoia Engine

The System

Zero Sum uses a simple D10 dice pool system. You roll a number of 10-sided dice equal to your Attribute + Skill. Any die that rolls a 7 or higher is a Success. Multiple successes determine the magnitude of your achievement.

The Cognitive Load & Paranoia Tracks

Instead of just tracking physical Health, characters track **Cognitive Load** and **Paranoia**. * **Cognitive Load**: Gained from physical exhaustion, close calls, and minor setbacks. High cognitive load penalizes rolls. * **Paranoia**: Gained when characters realize they are being watched, when an ally betrays them, or when they uncover terrifying truths. High paranoia forces characters to make irrational decisions to “stay safe” (e.g., abandoning a safehouse early, destroying perfectly good equipment, cutting ties with contacts).

The Heat Level

The Game Master (GM) maintains a **Heat Level** for the group (ranging from 1 to 10). * **Level 1-3**: Background checks, passive surveillance. * **Level 4-6**: Active tailing, frozen bank accounts, smear campaigns. * **Level 7-9**: Wanted by law enforcement, hitmen dispatched, media blackout. * **Level 10**: Total burn. The full force of the state or corporate security apparatus is hunting you.

Combat is Failure

If guns are drawn, the players have already made a mistake. Damage is realistic and devastating. There are no “hit points” that magically replenish. Wounds cause bleeding, infection, and severe mechanical penalties.

The “Twist” Mechanic

Once per session, the GM or the Players can spend a “Burn Point” to introduce a severe twist. A contact turns out to be a double agent; the encrypted drive actually contains a tracking virus; the safehouse is already compromised.